

MANUSCRIPT 6

[This fragment consists of pages 4 through 30 of what appears to be the first article in a series; Manuscript 7 (below) seems to be the second. Beginning with information taken from the journals of Juan Rodriguez de Cabrillo, the Portuguese explorer, and from various documents he found in mission archives, Bowers appears to have been searching for something that would shed light on the presumed disappearance of the Chumash. This initial section is followed by information obtained from Omset (probably pronounced Omtset), an old Indian from Santa Rosa Island. Omset told Bowers that his tribe was called Chumash. This name was later adopted to identify the people of the mainland coast, the Channel Islands, and the inland valleys who shared basic linguistic and cultural traits. Although Bowers consistently called these people Santa Barbara Indians, he apparently introduced the name Chumash into the literature. The next section of the manuscript consists of an account of the Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island, an Indian woman who was abandoned on this island for nearly 20 years. Most of the rest of the manuscript is devoted to descriptions of Chumash villages, with respect to aesthetics and defense. Finally, Bowers describes the "sweat lodge" of the California Indian, and includes a long and detailed description of the architectural features of a Pomo dance house and of a dance held within it. This description was copied by Bowers almost verbatim from a field notebook that is housed in the Special Collections Library at the Southwest Museum. It was Bowers' custom to copy his notes, often word for word, incorporating sections into finished manuscripts.]

...of Maj. J.W. Powell, embraces the whole of Santa Barbara and Ventura counties, with portions of Los Angeles and San Luis Obispo counties. We may also include the Channel Islands, which we have described, as belonging to the same people. Most of this territory, excepting two of the islands, possesses a climate of surpassing loveliness, where, under the civilization of the white man, cereals of all kinds, and every variety of northern and semi-tropical fruits seem to find their special adaptation.

This portion of California was discovered by Juan Rodriguez de Cabrillo in the year 1542, but half a century after Columbus discovered

sustenance on the products of the sea. Indeed there is no evidence that they cultivated the soil to the slightest degree. While the facts we have stated may cast some light on the decline of this unfortunate people, yet it is a great mystery how a population, numbering several thousand, could disappear from these islands in a little more than a decade, and without any reason of the cause being made by those to whose oversight they had been committed. In 1805 there were at least seven villages on Santa Rosa island, each "containing many Indians," according to the mission records, but about eleven years afterward they had been reduced to probably less than a score in numbers, when they were removed by the mission fathers and placed on the mainland.

In relation to the character of the islanders we have anything but a flattering picture drawn by the old *padres* of Santa Barbara Mission. Their record states that they were "very superstitious, and had a bad effect on the character of the Indians on the mainland. They came to the mainland in *cayercos* (canoes), and exchanged shell beads with the other Indians for seeds, which with the fish they caught, constituted their food. The men were entirely naked, and the women nearly so, and all were half starved." Undoubtedly the old *padres* looked with disfavor upon the islanders, while their efforts to win them to the faith was by no means remunerative.

The last survivor of the Santa Rosa islanders was still living in Santa Barbara County a few years since. His name was Omset, and he had left the island with the small remnant of his people nearly sixty years previously. Omset said his people were idolaters, worshipping the sun, the swordfish and the crow. They worshiped the sun because it gave them light and warmth, the swordfish because it killed the whale, which floating to the shore furnished them food. The worship of the crow by these people is also recorded by the historian of Cabrillo's expedition, but the object of this worship is not clear. The crow, or rather the raven (*Corvus corax*), is still quite abundant on this island, and very tame. Padre de la Ascensión, who accompanied the expedition of Vizcaino in 1600, describes a temple to the sun, erected by the natives of Santa Catalina Island, containing images and idols. Omset also represented his tribe, which was called *Chumas*, as very numerous previous to the advent of the Spaniards. "The men were stout, well built, and good swimmers." They ate their food uncooked.

About eighty miles southeast of Santa Barbara is a small island, some eight miles in length by three in breadth, named San Nicolas,

which once supported a dense population. As artificers in stone and bone they excelled the inhabitants on the other islands, and those on the mainland. The finest specimens of aboriginal workmanship I have seen in California came from this island. But little is known of the people who inhabited San Nicolas island, except the records of the industry represented by these specimens. Owing to its distance from the mainland it seems not to have been discovered by Cabrillo, Vancouver, nor by any of the early or intermediate explorers. It was visited by the early American fur traders, however, and was called by them "Sea Otter Island." In the summer of 1835 a schooner was dispatched to this island to bring off the remnant of its inhabitants, now reduced to seventeen or eighteen individuals. The cause of their declination is enshrouded in as great mystery as that of the other islanders.

When all were supposed to be ready to sail, and the ship was about to weigh anchor, one of the women requested permission to return for her child, which she had left in a cañon nearby. But during her absence a heavy wind commenced blowing and drove the vessel from the island. In due time the schooner reached San Pedro in Los Angeles County, where the Indians were landed, and she was immediately ordered north by her owner, but in attempting to enter the Golden Gate, at San Francisco, was capsized and lost. There being no other large craft on this portion of the coast, no attempt was made to rescue this unfortunate woman. Indeed no effort was made to learn her fate for seventeen years afterward, although it was well known that she had been abandoned on the island. In 1851 the place was visited by a small schooner in quest of the eggs of waterfowl, when human tracks were discovered in the sand, which seemed to be those of a woman, but before search could be initiated a strong wind arose and drove the party from the inhospitable island. The following year the island was again visited by this party, who on going ashore found a large basket, woven from a species of grass, containing a gown made of bird's skins, a sinew rope, bone knife, fishhooks of shell, and other things, covered with the skin of a seal, but a second time they were driven from the island by the wind. In the summer of 1853 the island was visited for the third time by this party, who succeeded in making a thorough exploration, finding the object of their search seated in a low circular enclosure of sage brush. Within the enclosure was a smoldering fire, while without was a large pile of bones and another of ashes, showing this to have been her abode for several years. She was engaged in recovering the blubber from a seal

skin, in which she employed a rude knife. She did not seem frightened, but met her rescuers with a smile and a bow. She wore a dress or gown made of bird skins, the feathers outside and pointing downward. Her hair was bleached by long exposure to a reddish brown, and hung down to her shoulders. Her features were regular and her complexion fairer than the Indians on the mainland. Though supposed to be about fifty years of age, her face was remarkably free from wrinkles. She willingly accompanied the party on board their vessel, and to the mainland. During her eighteen years of exile she seems to have entirely forgotten her language. Indians of various dialects were sent for, but none could understand her, nor she them. The change of diet to which she was subjected induced sickness, of which she died four weeks after reaching Santa Barbara. She made her rescuers understand by signs that she did not find her child but that it had been killed by dogs, a peculiar species that became extinct on this island but recently.

The civilization to which the Indians on the mainland were subjected proved fatal, and they too rapidly disappeared. Some half breeds, and a few claiming to be full blood, are occasionally met with, but I doubt if there are any of the pure Santa Barbara stock left. A few Indians linger about some of the old missions, but they have probably been brought from other families and tribes. The biennial report of the Santa Barbara Mission for 1793-4 shows that one thousand and fifteen had been added by baptism during the two years, but of this number all but one hundred and forty were adults. The number born in the mission was very small. The decline is attributed to the "dominant vice of incontinency, and the inhuman practice, only too common, especially along the (Santa Barbara) Channel from San Buenaventura to San Luis Obispo inclusive, of intentional abortion, or the smothering of the newly born by their mothers." This is the only record, as far as I can ascertain, relating to the cause of the declination of the teaming thousands occupying the shoreline, rivers, rivulets, potreros, and mountain summits, a century ago.

The "Native Californians" are descended from the early Spaniards and others intermarrying with the natives. They compose from a sixth to a tenth of the population, and are not usually a thrifty class; but there are some honorable exceptions. They speak an inferior Spanish, and nearly never acquire the English language at all. The women, when young, are generally straight and spare, with dark eyes and hair and finely chiseled features, but they usually become corpulent and homely